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INDIA'S YOUNG AND THE BREAKING POINT

From exam paper leaks to unemployment, the pressures driving a generation to the streets

Kunal Purohit

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Gulzar first came to Mumbai in the 1950s as a 16-year-old. (GETTY IMAGES AND SHANKER CHAKRAVARTY)

IN CONVERSATION

CITY OF GULZAR

In his new book, the veteran poet-lyricist pays tribute to Mumbai — the city that welcomed him as a teenage migrant and became his lifelong home

Devina Dutt

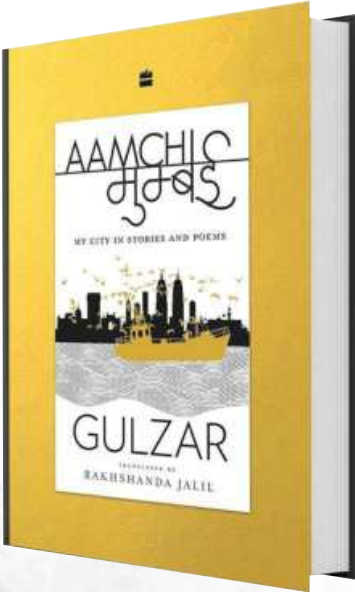
On one of those early monsoon days when the heavens seem to have opened up, I find myself in a cab winding up Bandra's Pali Hill. Through the grey haze and incessant, thick din of the downpour that defines the city of Mumbai at this time of the year, we stop at an unshowy white bungalow from another era. I am here to meet someone who started off almost as a castaway 76 years ago, a migrant like countless others, in a city that has since given him everything and that he has now called home for decades.

At 91, Gulzar, the beloved poet, writer, filmmaker and lyricist in Hindi films, has brought out a

new collection of poems and short stories titled *Aamchi Mumbai (My Mumbai)*. The anthology (published by HarperCollins) is as open and tactile, as reminiscent of the salt-flecked sea air of Mumbai, and as heterogenous as the city.

At times in the conversation, we might have come precariously close to invoking the typical clichés of a dream city but of course we don't. Gulzar's disarmingly accessible writing masks the way in which the poetic and writerly self remains grounded in the canny outsider's persona with a natural distance from his material.

And then there is the play of languages whose often alien idioms and rhythms might draw from North India, Urdu, his native Punjabi and his fascination with Bangla, but are uniquely alchemised in his writing and concerns as a Mumbaikar in the here and now.



A perfect springboard These are the impressions I carry with me into the interview at any rate. Looking for an opening, I venture to suggest that Gulzar came back to literature around 2000, after his film career of nearly four decades was winding down.

But it turns out that this is not a good start at all. Polite disapproval, if not open contradiction, appears on Gulzar's face before he explains, "I have always been with books and literature. I never left literature so there's no question of coming back. Films happened somewhere in the middle, settled me, gave me stability but it was always books and writing for me."

"Even when I joined films, I worked with Bimal Roy whose Hindi films drew mainly from Bangla literature," he continues. Indeed, Roy's best cinema drew from literature and included *Sujata* (1959), based on a short story by Subodh Ghosh, and *Bandini* (1963) based on a short story by Charu Chandra Chakraborty (pen name Jarasandha). Earlier, the classic *Do Bigha Zamin* in 1953 was inspired by a Rabindranath Tagore poem of the same name, with screenplay and music by Salil Chowdhury. *Devdas* in 1955 was based on a novel by the same name by Sarat

Chandra Chattopadhyay. But, it is in recalling his relationship with the city of Mumbai that Gulzar becomes truly animated. For the next two hours, he shares stories which reveal what makes the city so unique while also offering clues about how the country has changed since Independence.

A city of tough love "This city is like an elder brother. It keeps you close, handles things for you with the occasional box on the ears but it doesn't let you go," he declares.

Soon after he had received admission to St. Stephens College in Delhi, a 16-year-old Gulzar was given a one-way train ticket to Mumbai by family members and told to alight only once the destination was reached. From there, life unfolded as it has for many a migrant in the city. He lived in a sparse *chawl* opposite KEM Hospital in Dadar, the heart of the city.

Coming in to the city, his first encounter was with Irani restaurants and their unique subculture of a rough and ready friendliness. A memory that has stayed is of how convenient it was to survive on a meal of *keema pav* (minced meat with bun) for 25 paise. In a city that lacked public taps (*piaus* – a common sight in North India), Irani restaurants used to keep large trays filled with water. Anyone passing by could step inside and get a glass. At night, the same eateries would keep two vessels full of leftover Irani biryani for anyone looking for a free meal.

Today, Mumbai presents itself as a sharp-edged neo-liberal fantasy. Back then, it was also a city of creative ferment with a strong working-class movement. "You could get a copy of Tolstoy's *Resurrection* for 50 paise," Gulzar recalls with wonder. The great lyricist Shailendra, who infused the Hindi film lyric with a natural empathy for the common man, worked at the Matunga railway yard.

Like many other literature lovers, Gulzar's early years in the city were spent attending poetry readings and talks by stalwart poets of the Progressive Writers Group at Red Flag Hall in Khetwadi in the then culturally vibrant Girgaum area, where Rajinder Singh Bedi, Ali Sardar Jafri, Sahir Ludhianvi and many others gathered to read and mingle with ordinary people interested in literature.

But the city's once-strong working-class leanings have changed. "Political rallies were common and you had leaders like Comrade S.A. Dange, a stocky handsome man, leading from the front. We made way for them respectfully," he says.

"*Garibi mein jo garibi ki dignity thi, aaj usme sharmindgi hai* (the dignity of the working classes, even in their poverty, has been replaced with shame)," he says.

Living in Mumbai, it was natural that he had close relationships with Marathi writers like P.L. Deshpande and V.V. Shirwadkar (Kusumagraj), and among younger contemporaries, the poet and critic Dilip Chitre. "If you have the urge to meet fellow writers, you pick up things and make friendships," he says.

The writer and curator is co-founder of First Edition Arts, a performing arts company.

ONE FOR THE ROAD

Pages that travel

Five new books transporting readers across centuries, continents and imagined futures

Swati Daftuar

This month's reading list is proof that books remain the most efficient form of transport. One moment, you are in ancient Rome watching a republic edge towards dictatorship; the next, you are in present-day Mumbai, where property, marriage and social standing are all part of the same intricate negotiation. From there, it's on to speculative futures powered by unsettling technology, New England family dramas tinged with folklore, and quietly devastating stories about memory and the lives we think we've left behind.

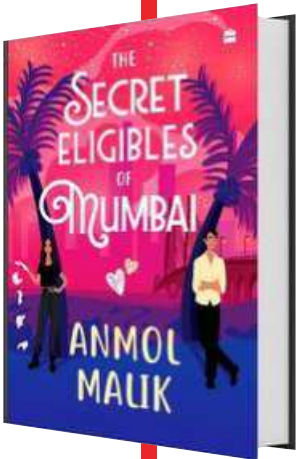


It Will Come Back to You |

Sigrid Nunez

The American writer's remarkable new collection brings together 13 stories written over more than three decades. Her characters are writers, mothers, daughters, siblings and solitary people, looking back at their lives and discovering that memory often preserves the oddest details while blurring the things that once seemed important. Nunez's voice is conversational and funny, with an awareness of illness, ageing, regret and death, running just below the surface.

(Virago; ₹599)

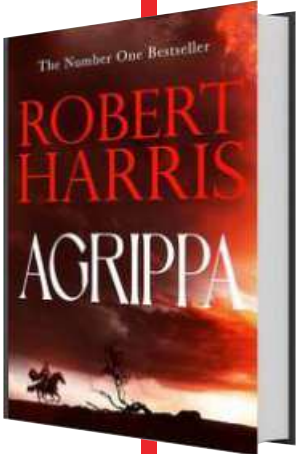


The Secret Eligibles of Mumbai |

Anmol Malik

In a buoyant, unabashedly *filmi* and gloriously maximalist Mumbai, the charming, rich and wily Dharam Ved is determined to woo Andie, the younger daughter of Prakash McMiller, who made his fortune making dustbins. But when Dharam finds himself repeatedly sparring with the furious yet funny older daughter, Iman, he is forced to reconsider his motives. Beneath the cheerful chaos of this rom-com lies a sharp understanding of how quickly money determines who is considered respectable or eligible.

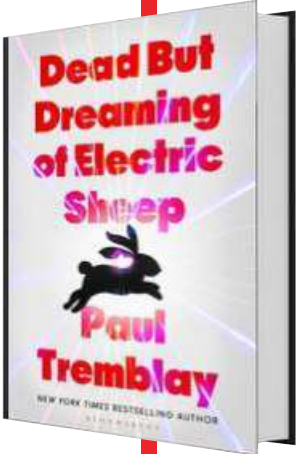
(HarperCollins India; ₹399)



Agrippa | Robert Harris

This is the story of Marcus Agrippa, the Roman soldier, strategist and builder who helped make Augustus Caesar's rule possible, while largely remaining in the shadows. Harris gives him the floor, imagining the ageing general looking back on the friendship that determined his life. Battles, betrayals, marriages and political bargains arrive with the clean propulsion of a thriller, while Agrippa's plain, soldierly voice keeps the spectacle human.

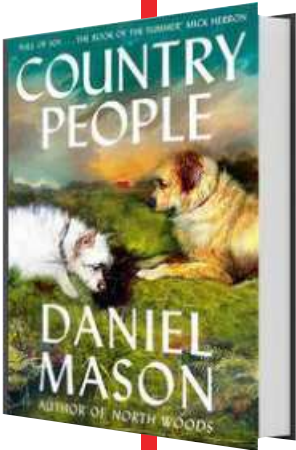
(Penguin; ₹999)



Dead but Dreaming of Electric Sheep | Paul Tremblay

In this dystopian horror novel, a man in a near-permanent coma is implanted with experimental technology that allows another person to control his muscles. Underemployed gamer Julia Flang is asked by her powerful tech executive mother to use a gaming console-of-sorts to move and guide the man across America. Tremblay turns this wonderfully grotesque premise into something funny, frightening and unexpectedly sad – raising important questions about bodily autonomy and artificial intelligence.

(Bloomsbury; ₹1,634 [ebook])



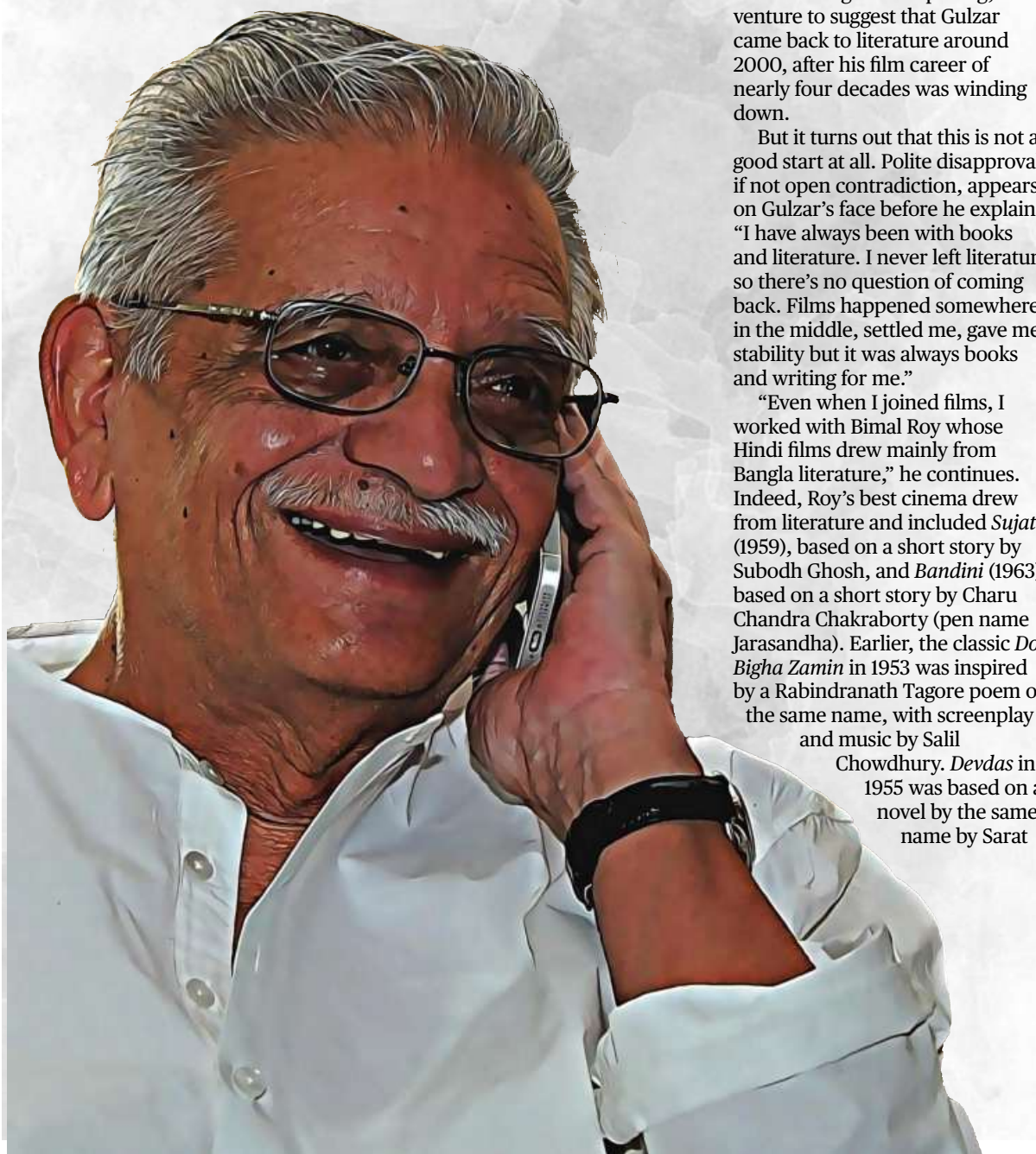
Country People | Daniel Mason

When an academic accepts a year-long visiting professorship in Vermont, her family moves with her from California to live in a borrowed country house. As she heads to campus, her husband, Miles, contends with childcare and the home, not to mention his long-pending Ph.D thesis. The pleasure of this novel lies in watching this ordinary family gradually become tangled in folklore, conspiracy and the unseen world beneath the mountains.

(Hachette India; ₹799)

(A monthly column on popular fiction.)

The writer is an independent journalist, editor, and literary curator.





EXTRACT

Sobhana K. Naïr

On June 23, 1947, less than two months before the two countries declared independence, Pakistan’s soon-to-be-appointed Governor-General Mohammed Ali Jinnah, at a meeting with Mountbatten, wondered where the constituent assembly of the yet-to-be-born country should sit. Here in Delhi or in Karachi? The Indian Constituent Assembly was holding regular meetings at the Library Hall of the Council House. The Legislative Council Chamber was now permanently in use by the Federal Court. But the Legislative Assembly chamber was lying vacant. Rather nonchalantly, Mountbatten said that Delhi would be a more convenient place. The Indian side had already stolen a march. The Constituent Assembly had been sitting since 1946.

A proposal abandoned
On the eve of Independence and the

WHEN JINNAH LOOKED TO DELHI

In June 1947, he explored convening Pakistan’s Constituent Assembly in Delhi, but the proposal was opposed by Nehru, Patel, and Rajendra Prasad

great Partition that would tear asunder the Indian subcontinent, Jinnah said he was hoping to begin the session in the middle of July. Would the Congress be amenable to the suggestion, he wondered. Mountbatten waived off his concern saying that he would broach the topic with the Indian Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru. The next day,

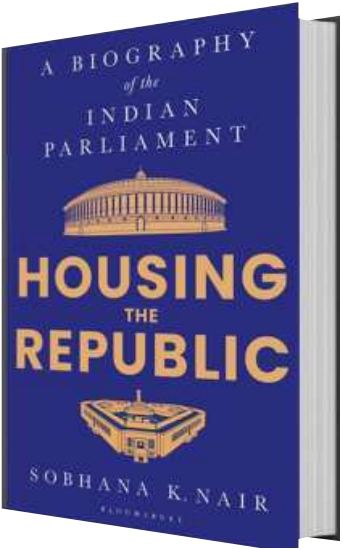
Mountbatten met Nehru. “I had strongly recommended that it should be in Delhi in the first instance so that they could obtain the benefit of close contact with the Indian Constituent Assembly,” Mountbatten said. Nehru also saw an advantage in the plan. But ever the democrat, he didn’t want to commit without

consulting his cabinet. He murmured that it could be done if only the “accommodation difficulties could be overcome”. Nehru wrote back to Mountbatten the same day: “I have thought over this matter and consulted some of my colleagues including Sardar Patel. Their reaction has been entirely unfavourable and I agree with it.”

(R-L): Muhammed Ali Jinnah, Lord Mountbatten, and Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru discuss Partition in 1946. (GETTY IMAGES)

One doesn’t know what transpired when Nehru informed his cabinet colleagues, especially Sardar Patel and Rajendra Prasad. The alacrity with which it was rejected hints at a strong pushback from the two. Nehru responded, “For it to meet about the same time as the Constituent Assembly of India and possibly in the same building would lead to difficult and embarrassing situations. There is every likelihood of demonstrations and possible rival demonstrations. This might even result in conflict. All this would be a bad beginning or the order of things.” Mountbatten met Sardar Patel and Rajendra Prasad individually too, to discuss the idea, but both turned him down. The idea was promptly dropped.

There were enough grounds for concern that such a meeting could turn violent. Only days earlier, Jinnah had been attacked in Delhi. The All-India Muslim League’s council was meeting in the ballroom on the first floor of the Imperial Hotel. Just as deliberations were winding down, Khaksars brandishing *belchas* (sharpened spades) burst through the garden at the side of the hotel, startling the residents who had settled down for the evening tea in the hotel garden. “Get Jinnah!” they shouted, all the while swinging their weapons and wrecking the hotel. They nearly climbed halfway up the staircase leading to the ballroom where Jinnah and the council were still in session before the Muslim League national guards could grapple with them and



turn them back. The police rushed in with tear gas to control the situation. Jinnah behaved with great composure, Sidney Smith of the *Daily Express*, who saw him afterwards, reported.

The Khaksars, or ‘servants of the dust’, were part of an armed movement to free India that was founded in 1931 by Allama Inayatullah Khan Mashriqi in Lahore. Mashriqi came from an affluent family in Amritsar. He was academically bright. From 1907 to 1912, he spent four years at the University of Cambridge, completing a tripos in four subjects, an unheard-of feat that earned him top headlines in British and Indian newspapers. Mashriqi believed partitioning the continent into two countries was essentially a British idea, a continuation of their divide-and-rule theory. Dividing the country on religious lines, he felt, would promote fundamentalism on both sides of the border. One can argue about Mashriqi’s means but his prediction could not have been more spot on.

Inaugurating Parliament
The inaugural session of the Constituent Assembly of Pakistan was thus held on August 10, 1947, also marking Pakistan’s Independence day in the Provincial Legislative Assembly of Sindh in Karachi. This building, much like the Indian Parliament, was also constructed by the British. It was here that the Objective Resolution, Pakistan’s first constitutional document, and the 1956 Constitution of the Islamic Republic of Pakistan were adopted. After the adoption of the 1962 Constitution of Pakistan, parliamentary sessions were held both in Dhaka and at a newly constructed building at Rawalpindi called Ayub Hall. The Parliament was unicameral under the 1962 Constitution. From 1972 onwards, the State Bank auditorium in Islamabad functioned as the National Assembly of Pakistan. Under the Interim Constitution of Pakistan, which was adopted in April 1972, Pakistan’s first bicameral legislature was established. The Constitution of the Islamic Republic of Pakistan was later adopted in 1973. The Parliament House building in Islamabad, the capital city of Pakistan, was inaugurated on May 28, 1986. It took 11 years to build.

Excerpt from Housing the Republic: A Biography of the Indian Parliament (Bloomsbury Publishing).

Mehul Devkala

Monsoon arrived in Gujarat just as I finished reading *Homes without Windows*, a collection of 11 autobiographical essays by Dalit activist Chandu Maheria, translated by Hemang Ashwinkumar. Originally written in the Gujarati and published in non-literary magazines, these essays are now available in English.

“Today, when I utter stuff like I don’t like monsoon or the prospect of getting wet in rain, my audience gasps, their eyebrows raised in mock surprise. How could someone, who has spent most of his life’s monsoons in just two pairs of mostly wet clothes, still like to get soaked is a question beyond them...,” writes Maheria in one of the essays. For him, the monsoon evokes memories of hellish public toilets, the scramble to cover the house with a sheet of cheap tarpaulin, rainwater flooding homes and streets, and his mother praying to Varun, the god of rain. In the *chawls* of Rajpur, where Maheria spent most of his life, there was little time to marvel at the beauty of a rainbow.

A life of deprivation
When you enter Ahmedabad, the commercial capital of Gujarat, from the eastern side, a dense web of chawls lines both sides of the main road, inhabited mostly by Muslims, Dalits, Christians, and poor communities. Maheria takes us into the heart of this labyrinth. He introduces us to its seasons and festivals, its sorrows and moments of happiness despite scarcity and untouchability, its schools, toilets, and hospitals, and the enduring presence of B.R. Ambedkar and M.K. Gandhi in the lives of its people.

Maheria’s childhood was marked by extreme food deprivation. His father, a textile mill worker, was the



Homes without Windows
Chandu Maheria, transl by Hemang Ashwinkumar
Juggernaut
₹699

sole breadwinner of a family of nine. During Maheria’s early school years, the children received a glass of milk every day before classes, but little else. Maheria writes about those dark days with disarming honesty. There were times when a relative who delivered tiffin boxes would stop by their home at the end of his rounds and let the family eat the leftovers from the boxes. At the end of the chapter, Maheria expresses his gratitude for the reservation policy, which enabled him and his siblings to pursue education and secure jobs and escape those years of hardship. In another chapter, he writes, “As if the question of filling the bottomless pits of hunger was not vexed enough, the daily dilemma of emptying our bowels had made our lives, both personal and social, embarrassing and miserable.” Their dingy dwelling, Abu Kasai’s chawl, did not have a single public toilet of its own, forcing its residents to use the filthy toilets in the neighbouring Hiralal’s chawl. Decades later, a large, modern, and well-maintained



Unflinching portrait of Dalit life

Chandu Maheria’s book offers an intimate account of caste, poverty, and survival in urban Gujarat but is undermined by an embellished translation

public toilet stands there, yet it remains beyond the reach of the daily-wage poor and the unemployed because it costs one rupee per visit. As a result, it is seldom used by the local residents, who have wryly come to call it ‘The Mayor’s Bungalow’.

Maheria, a noted scholar of Dalit life in Gujarat, has important points to make in the ever-contentious debate on Gandhi and Ambedkar. Unlike many of his Dalit friends, he admires Gandhi. He writes,

“Gandhi might have been anything – call him whatever names – but one thing he was certainly not was anti-Dalit.” Maheria loved wearing Khadi despite his mother’s opposition; his father too was anti-Gandhi. Yet Maheria affectionately refers to Gandhi as “That Fellow, Gandhido.”

When Maheria was just two years away from retirement, he received a promotion along with a transfer to a town called Dhoraji in the Saurashtra region. There the

author says he repeatedly encountered the question, “*Tame keva?* (What caste are you?)”, which he had never been asked in urban Gujarat. While much of his writing focuses on Dalit life in urban Gujarat, his two-year stay in this dusty town offers a glimpse into caste discrimination and the ways in which Dalits and Muslims are excluded from the broader development agenda. It also shows how these communities are pushed into segregated ghettos on the

outskirts of so-called developing towns.

Losing the writer’s voice
Having read the original Gujarati essays alongside their English translations, I have a few observations about Ashwinkumar’s translation. A translator’s foremost responsibility is to preserve the original author’s voice and tonal quality. Maheria’s language is simple and he rarely uses ornamental expressions; his economy of words is almost Gandhian.

In many places, however, the English translation departs from this restraint by adding flourishes. In the chapter on Diwali, for instance, the translation reads: “Ramanbhai worked tirelessly...treating the wall as a wide canvas, painting it in broad strokes. Thanks to his speed and finesse, the whole drawing room, the biggest room in the house, would be taken care of by the afternoon.” In the original Gujarati, this is a single sentence. The added phrases do not align with Maheria’s sparse style. Moreover, the sentence is factually inaccurate: in the original, there is no drawing room; it refers instead to a small, single thatched room in a chawl. The use of the words “drawing room” creates a misleading impression. A translator should remain faithful to the original text and avoid such liberties.

Despite these concerns, *Homes Without Windows* remains an important and deeply affecting work. Maheria’s essays offer an intimate, lived account of caste, poverty, and survival in urban Gujarat. What stays with the reader is the dignity and wit with which he recounts them. Maheria’s voice continues to insist on being heard.

The reviewer is a Gujarati poet, writer, and award-winning filmmaker.

Kunal Purohit

Sitting in his family home in Bihar's Nawada town, Abhishek Kumar has spent the last week glued to his phone. A bout of typhoid has left him barely able to walk, but he cannot look away. On his screen, the protests at Jantar Mantar unfold, stirring a powerful sense of déjà vu.

He understands the protesters' anger. In December 2024, the 28-year-old was among hundreds of aspirants who spent three months braving the biting cold, sleeping in the open at Patna's iconic Gandhi Maidan to demand action over the alleged leak of the Bihar Public Service Commission (BPSC) exam papers they had taken.

It was just one of nearly 150 competitive examinations Kumar says he has appeared for over the past nine years.

The protests amounted to nothing. As did Kumar's (CJP)-led protests rocking the capital. "We are broken now. We have lost all hope," he says. "That is why this protest is needed."

A platform of their own
Like Kumar, thousands of young Indians are angry and no

Staring at a crisis

80% of India's unemployed are in the 15-24 age group

29.1% unemployment rate among graduates

7-8 million young Indians are added to the workforce every year

82% of India's workforce is employed in the informal sector

40% estimated migration rate in India in 2030, bulk of which will be linked to employment

(Source: India Employment Report (2024) by International Labour Organization and Institute for Human Development)

longer able to swallow their despair. The CJP protest, which began in early June in central Delhi's Jantar Mantar area,

started off demanding accountability for botched examinations and paper leaks – more than 2 million candidates had to re-appear for the National Eligibility Cum Entrance Test (NEET) after the question paper was leaked in May. On July 18, educator-environmentalist

Sonam Wangchuk, who was on a hunger strike as a part of the protests, was forcibly moved from Jantar Mantar to Safdarjung Hospital. Since then, protests have broken out across the country, from Mumbai to Kolkata, Bengaluru to Panjim to Dehradun.

The protesters cut across party lines – while Left student bodies have been active, many people have also claimed to be Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) voters in the past. For all of them, the protest has become a platform to voice their long-held frustrations.

The grievances are many: from poor quality education and compromised examinations to the lack of jobs. But above all, they are united by the anger of not being heard on issues that matter to them.

"Many youngsters believe that the freedom to come together, to collectivise and demand rights has vanished in the last few years," says Vinita Singh, founder-trustee of We, The People, an NGO that promotes constitutional literacy. "The Jantar Mantar protests have given people a collective voice. That is why these protests feel like a celebration."

She is referring to the visuals of people using music, memes and catchy slogans to poke fun at the government. "They know the issues are not going to get resolved just yet. But at least they have a platform now," Singh adds.

Fighting apathy

According to the India Employment Report 2024, the youth make up about 80% of the total unemployed population in the country. This isn't because they aren't



INDIA'S YOUNG AND THE BREAKING POINT

equipped for good jobs. Government data shows that only 15% of those trained under the Narendra Modi government's flagship skill development programme, the Pradhan Mantri Kaushal Vikas Yojana, have managed to land jobs in the last 10 years.

Beyond the lack of jobs and the state of education, many young Indians are also anxious about ecological and climate issues, as per a survey last year among 16- to 25-year-old Indians by *Down To Earth* magazine.

Across the globe – from Serbia to Morocco, Kenya to Indonesia, and closer home, in Sri Lanka, Bangladesh and

Nepal – millions of young people have stood up to unresponsive governments, demanding change and accountability. Some of these movements have resulted in regime changes, especially in South Asia, while others have led to policy reversals as well as reforms, like in Indonesia and Morocco.

In India too, the CJP protest has resonated with many young people, not only because of its demands, but because the government's response to it mirrors what they say has become their everyday experience of the Indian state.

One of them is 30-year-old Bhushan Unde, who has been

following the protests from Raveri village in Maharashtra's Yavatmal district, nearly 1,200 kilometres from Jantar Mantar.

Born to farmer-parents, Unde studied hard to earn an M.Sc degree, a rarity in his village. Yet, he has managed to find only menial, contractual jobs that require nothing more than basic literacy – his last job was as a daily-entry operator. Farming incomes have been steadily falling in this region while the cost of living has gone up. Over the last few months, Unde has had difficulty sourcing diesel and fertiliser due to the ongoing West Asia conflict. And his motorcycle has needed repairs as a result of using



Scenes from the CJP-led protests in New Delhi last week (above) founder Abhijit Dipke greets protesters at Jantar Mantar. (CJP) KUMAR, PUSHPAKAR, REUTERS, ANI

ethanol-blended petrol. Amidst all this, Unde says he has felt one constant – a missing government. "It feels like the government just doesn't respond to our concerns. Be it over bigger issues like the job crisis, or even smaller issues like ethanol, you just don't see the government trying to address people's concerns," he says.

The CJP protest, Unde believes, is a culmination of all of this. "For some time now, it has felt like the government has gagged our mouths and plugged our ears," he says, pointing to the increasing censorship of social media posts.

In 2024, the Modi government passed just over 12,000 orders to take down online content. This number doubled to over 24,000 in 2025. Over the last few months, several videos containing remarks critical of the Modi government's policies have been taken down.

"People have held their breaths for far too long," says



It feels like the government just doesn't respond to our concerns. Be it over bigger issues like the job crisis, or even smaller ones like ethanol-blended petrol, you just don't see the state trying to address people's concerns

BHUSHAN UNDE Farmer in Yavatmal, Maharashtra



Increasingly, there is a feeling amongst sections of young people that they don't want to be manipulated, they don't want to be fobbed off and patronised. They want something to hope for

SHAKUNTALA BANAJI Professor, London School of Economics



I don't hope for much. India is a massive country and things don't change overnight. But, maybe we will just be able to breathe again

AFAQ WANI Automotive professional



Many youngsters believe that the freedom to come together, to collectivise and demand rights has vanished in the last few years. The Jantar Mantar protests have given people a collective voice. That is why these protests feel like a celebration

VINITA SINGH Founder-trustee of We, The People

the country. It feels like the government is so thick-skinned that it doesn't care about us any more," she says. "People have completely lost hope that things will change."

According to Shaktantala Banaji, professor of media, culture and social change at London School of Economics, the protest is a reaction to the everyday injustices that youngsters suffer, and their inability to change them. "The young people I've spoken with over the past years have expressed a mixture of emotions, from shame and despair to feeling a lack of courage to speak out against the injustices and prejudices they see and hear around them," she says. Banaji is working on a book on young people across India, U.K., South Africa, Peru, Nigeria, China and Colombia.

"Increasingly, there is a feeling amongst sections of young people that they don't

singing songs. Even then, you are shooing us away. What is this freedom of expression you boast about then?" she says, just before the police arrive and detain her with her family.

They spent nearly five hours at the Worli police station, and her son is traumatised by the events, says Panaskar, adding that she has no regrets, however. "For years, I have been feeling a sense of rage at the state of



23 lakh young Indians appeared for the NEET undergraduate exam in 2025

1.36 lakh MBBS seats up for grabs for NEET aspirants

GREEN HUMOUR

Rohan Chakravarty



The other day I got the shock of my life. A post popped up on Instagram claiming that, henceforth, anyone who took a screen-capture of someone else's post, that person would receive a notification. Luckily, it was not true. But for a few terrifying moments, my heart stopped.

Screenshots are probably one of the best things ever invented. It allows us to lurk online and comment from the sidelines without alerting anyone. In Bengali, there is a popular phrase – PNPC or *poro ninda poro chorchha*, basically gossiping and complaining about others and dissecting their flaws. The screenshot is its digital manifestation, one picture worth a thousand PNPC words.

Big brother and private sphere

Honestly, screenshots are what keeps us sane in this troubled world where the nanny state is constantly trying to tell you what to think and monitors what you say. After the controversy around the film *Sattu*, one hears the government is planning to bring OTT films under CBFC certification norms. India already ranks 24th out of 33 countries surveyed by the U.S.-based think tank *The Future of Free Speech*. X (erstwhile Twitter) has already geo-blocked consensual sexual content from its platform, not just handles accused of peddling child pornography or misusing the Grok AI bot.

It's not just in India. The U.S. requires most visa applicants to disclose social media handles and usernames used in the last five years for vetting, while some applicants are instructed to make their profiles public for consular reviews.

It seems the private sphere is ever shrinking, besieged from all sides, with our digital and physical lives constantly monitored, ostensibly for our own well-being. Government agencies everywhere require us to reveal more and more of our private information. Companies surveil us to know what ads to show us. The screenshot, oddly,



POP-A-RAZZI

In screenshots we trust

Why screen-captures remain one of the last bastions of freedom

is one way to retain control over the private without feeling monitored and judged by the world at large.

In an essay for *The New York Times Magazine*, Oly Chang wrote "in many ways, screenshots are like your nudes: personal and deployed for a select audience." Ironically, or perhaps aptly, the first known "screenshot" was from 1959, a Polaroid photograph of a U.S. military computer screen displaying a pin-up model. That Polaroid, in retrospect, was essentially a screenshot.

There was even a device called the NPC Screenshooter, which used a Polaroid camera housed in a light-tight hood, and was advertised as the "simplest and most economical way to make photographs and slides directly from your computer's monitor." By 1960, digital techniques to take a screen-capture had been developed. By the 1980s, IBM PC keyboards came with a Print Screen key and the term

"screenshot" had entered the computing lexicon. Now, smartphones are making it even easier to screenshot things we want to make a note of.

But it was only in that moment of panic when I thought my screenshots would no longer be quite so private that I realised what screenshots really mean. It's not just about making snide comments on people's posts without letting them know; though, of course, there is unadulterated glee in that. But as Chang points out in the same essay, screenshots, rather than the photo gallery, tell the story of who we really are. Photos, Chang wrote, "are often poised and polished" and, therefore, have a "sense of exteriority to them". A traditional diary cannot keep up with the breakneck pace of the world around us. Screenshots reflect our true messy, smutty selves in all their glorious pettiness. We

save screenshots of moments of joy (that first Queen Bee accomplishment in *The New York Times* Spelling Bee), humiliation, outrage, schadenfreude, and restaurants we hope to try. In our screenshots folder, we can truly say, all are naked in the *hamaana*. And the great power of a screenshot is that it does not just document an event. It allows us to make information portable, share it with a new audience, embellish it with an eye roll, all without anyone being the wiser.

That is why screenshots remain one of the last bastions of freedom. As it is we have all inadvertently forwarded that screenshots folder, we can truly say, all are naked in the *hamaana*. And the great power of a screenshot is that it does not just document an event. It allows us to make information portable, share it with a new audience, embellish it with an eye roll, all without anyone being the wiser.

In a world where screens have taken over our lives, the screenshot is our reminder that we can still have the last word.

Sandip Roy is the author of Chapal Rani, the Last Queen of Bengal.

ARUNDHATI ROY

'WE ARE BEING PUSHED TO THE WALL'

The writer-activist, and other public figures, on the protests shaping India today



Leading by example Arundhati Roy has remained a voice of conscience, standing by the youth, from anti-CAA-NRC protests to the recent students' hunger strike led by the Cockroach Janta Party. (GETTY IMAGES)

Tanushree Ghosh

tanushree.ghosh@thehindu.co.in

Question: What has changed now? How is today's young India different from before? Is this CJP-student protest akin to the JP Movement of the 1970s in any way?

Answer: I think the protest has grown beyond the demands of the students. [Union Education Minister] Dharmendra Pradhan is small potatoes now. These young students have reclaimed what their parents' generation gave up. India's dignity. With their grace, courage and humour they have shown us how not to be afraid. It's a gift. It's up to us to use it well.

And no, I don't think it's like JP's movement at all. It's its own unique thing, and still a developing story. But I think it's exhilarating.

Q: The country has also been seeing other kinds of protests from the *Adivasi* protest in Madhya Pradesh to environmental protests, statehood protest, etc. Could all these together become something bigger?

A: Well, while all these movements are happening, we are also being pushed to the wall. The SIR [Special Intensive Revision] is the CAA-NRC in disguise. From fighting for our land, for our right to food and information, we are now fighting

for our right to vote. For our citizenship, which [German-American historian and philosopher] Hannah Arendt said was "the right to have rights". It's the Hindu Rashtra version of the 1935 Nuremberg laws where the Nazi government conferred citizenship based on "legacy papers" generated by itself. This government doesn't care about protest because it has captured the election machinery and feels it has the money and the might never to lose an election. But the Cockroaches could mark the beginning of the end of this regime. But spontaneous anger isn't enough. We need adults and political organisations to step in.



July 20 was my father's [Naseeruddin Shah] birthday and he really wanted to go to Delhi, but was in Chennai for a shoot. He's sending solidarity and strength to the students and youngsters out there and everybody fighting the good fight. It's one of the most significant protests that all of us have seen along with the NRC [National Register of Citizens], the farmers' protests and the wrestlers' protests. The problems that beset young people have not been addressed by the country's authorities. Their silence has spoken volumes. I really hope they listen to reason

VIVAAN SHAH Actor, theatre director



It is not a question of young or old. From 2014 onwards, all true citizens have been realising that those in power are just a mafia gang. By true citizens, I mean those who did not sell their souls first to the British before Independence and to America and Israel thereafter

ANAND PATWARDHAN Documentary filmmaker (filmed the 1970s JP Movement in Kranti Ki Tarangin) [Waves of Revolution, 1974]



We need to be more sensitive towards the youth. They have not given up their lives. We have taken their lives. What I hope for is change — in the way we as a society and as an establishment have misunderstood the youth of India

RAKEYSH OMPRAKASH MEHRA Filmmaker (*Rang De Basanti*, 2006)

PRAKASH RAJ Actor, director



I went to the protest on July 20. It was hot, but the energy was incredible. The anger is not about just one exam [NEET] being leaked, but that our voice is being ignored. Students have stopped responding to the usual dog whistles of religion that were used to divide us. My hope is that we will get a government that is more responsive. At least, acknowledge. [Lok Sabha MP] Hema Malini says don't protest, you must talk to us. But talk with whom? Look at Nepal, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka. Young people everywhere have triggered this and the government is utterly scared, which is why they had put Sonam Wangchuk under NSA [National Security Act] in Ladakh

RAHUL RAM Musician with Indian Ocean, co-host of *Aisi Patsi Democracy*

I stood witness through the night at Jantar Mantar to what transpired. The CJP are not fighting an election, or ideologically fighting against another political party. It is a group of youngsters coming together on the streets over an issue. And they have a single issue — accountability for the broken education system. Why doesn't this regime want to engage in dialogue and instead lathi-charge the students? We are not fools to stand apart. As an elder, as a citizen, as an artist, I need to go and give these children moral support. The government should understand that a movement is churning

YOGENDRA YADAV National convenor of Bharat Jodo Abhiyaan, founding member of Swaraj India and Jai Kisan Andolan

– With inputs from Surya Praphulla Kumar



I feel the present generation is fearless when it comes to putting forward their opinion. People comment on the Internet quite critically, and that has given [a certain] confidence to the youth. That is now being reflected on the ground where people, despite police brutality, have still turned out in huge numbers. They are fearless, they don't cower when threatened. They are not afraid to put forward what they think

SAURAV DAS Spokesperson, Cockroach Janta Party



After half a century, this protest has brought back the youth, with their agenda of education and employment, to the centre of the national stage. It has opened a window for democratic resistance in the face of creeping electoral autocracy

YOGENDRA YADAV National convenor of Bharat Jodo Abhiyaan, founding member of Swaraj India and Jai Kisan Andolan

– With inputs from Surya Praphulla Kumar

Dear readers, it will come as no surprise to regular consumers of this column that I routinely receive several hundreds of emails every day from people just like you.

Okay, fine. When I say several hundred, I mean three, and when I say every day, I mean since February. But still, this is nothing to scoff at. Please control your jealousy.

Earlier this week, I received an email from a young reader of this column. “Dear Mr. Vadukut,” she wrote. “I need your urgent, and wise, help with something. There are a few things happening these days in India that I am unhappy about. I have been discussing this with my friends. We are thinking of organising a protest of some kind. But I am not sure if this is a good idea. Can you please help?”

Readers, what do you think my response was to this email? Exactly. As a patriotic Indian, I immediately sent her details to the Intelligence Bureau and the Research and Analysis Wing.

As a famous poet once said: *Where the mind is without fear and the head is held high;/Where knowledge is free... but don't do nonsense things, we will file an FIR.*

This letter from the reader did make me think, however. Protesting in India is a very complicated thing. You have to think about it very carefully. And ideally from abroad after emigrating.

First of all, you should never protest against the honourable Prime Minister or any other senior ministers. These are all offices that deserve the highest dignity and we should not do anything to bring disrepute to these offices by way of criticism. Questioning them is an insult to the whole country itself.

Secondly, should you protest against government agencies such as the



Dissency

TRICKTIONARY EPISODE 35

VALID AND INVALID CAUSES

It is important to have a sense of proportion when thinking of protesting

Dissency
/di'sensi/
noun

Definition: The practice of restricting one's protests to topics that are fully acceptable to all concerned authorities.

Related forms:

Indiscent (adjective): Describing any protest that violates the principles of dissency.

Indissency (noun): The offence of protesting in a manner or on a topic that brings shame upon the republic and its leaders, usually due to foreign deep state interference.

Army, Navy, Air Force, police, CRPF, CISF, Indo-Tibetan Border Force or Coast Guard? What are we? A banana republic? Absolutely, totally, 100% you should not. These are all men and women who are proudly serving the people of this country. They are sacrificing their today so we can enjoy our tomorrow. Just because they serve the people of India, does not mean that the people of India can sit on their heads. This is not allowed.

Thirdly, we should never protest about some issue that has been reported in the news or on social media. You may be thinking: but Mr. Sidin, isn't the function of media to help us identify problems in the country?

Absolutely 100% wrong. The function of the media is to make sure that every Indian citizen is proud of the country. Sometimes, this means being suspicious of our fellow citizens. But that is perfectly fine. Eternal

suspicion is the price of liberty. In fact, if you ever see anything on the Internet that is critical of India, then it is highly likely that it is a conspiracy by foreign countries to undermine the India story. Which country? There are so many. Everyone is so jealous. Please avoid such protests.

Fourthly, it might be tempting to protest things like floods, potholes, broken bridges, leaked exam papers and the like. I understand the temptation. But it is important to keep in mind that these things also happen in other countries. How is it fair to protest for such reasons when people in other countries are not protesting? Also on a per-capita basis, how many potholes are there in India? Four? Five? That is nothing. It is important to have a sense of proportion when you think of protesting.

In fact, the more I think about this, the more I am convinced that we need a word to describe the kind of issues and topics that are legitimate reasons for protests in India. This will make it much easier for people, especially the youth, to choose carefully before challenging the status quo.

And that word is: dissency.

Example sentence: “The students demonstrated remarkable dissency by cancelling their protest against the leaked exam papers and instead organising a gratitude march thanking the examination board for creating greater academic challenge and motivation by distributing the papers in advance.”

Have you thought of protesting recently? How dare you!

Sidin Vadukut helps early stage companies communicate better. He blogs at www.whatay.com.

GOREN BRIDGE

Back and forth

Both vulnerable. South deals

Bob Jones

North couldn't help but bid a slam after South opened the bidding. South had a dead minimum, however, and slam was a tricky proposition.

The first sight of dummy told South that he only had nine top tricks and he needed three more. The club suit had a reasonable chance for development, needing a 3-3 split or for East to hold

the queen. That would only give him two extra tricks, however, and he needed three, so he decided to play on hearts first. He won the opening spade lead in hand with the king and led a low heart toward the dummy. West had to play low or South would have four heart tricks, and dummy's queen won the trick. Had East held the king, South would have needed a 3-3 heart split. South still needed a 3-3 heart split if he continued playing

on hearts, but the club suit, with the extra chance of East holding the queen, now became a better chance. South led a low club from the dummy and East hopped up with queen. South won the spade continuation with dummy's ace and led a club to his jack. When both opponents followed suit, he could claim his slam. Two spade tricks, two heart tricks, four diamonds, and four clubs. Well played!

NORTH
♠ A 7 2
♥ Q 5
♦ A K 3
♣ A K 7 6 4

WEST
♠ J 10 9 8 4
♥ K 10 9 6
♦ 10 9
♣ 9 8

EAST
♠ Q 6 3
♥ 8 2
♦ 7 6 5 2
♣ Q 10 5 2

SOUTH
♠ K 5
♥ A J 7 4 3
♦ Q J 8 4
♣ J 3

The bidding:
SOUTH 1♥
2♦
2NT
*Game forcing

WEST Pass
Pass
Pass

NORTH 2♣*
2♠
6NT

EAST Pass
Pass
All pass

Opening lead: Jack of ♠

QUIZ

Easy like Sunday morning

Birthdays of the day!

Berty Ashley

1 Born on this date in 1856, George Bernard Shaw was an Irish playwright who is regarded as one of the greatest dramatists of his generation. In 1925, his literary works earned him an iconic award. In 1938, his play *Pygmalion* was made into a film, which went on to win an iconic award in its field. Thereby, he became the first person to win which two awards?

2 Born on this date in 1875, Carl Jung was one of the most influential psychologists of all time. In 2019, this band based their album 'Map of the Soul: Persona' on his work. The songs refer to 'persona', 'shadow', and 'ego' from his theories. Which pathbreaking Korean band is this?

3 Born on this date in 1894, Aldous Huxley was a novelist whose prolific output led to him being nominated for a Nobel Prize in Literature nine times. His defining work was *Brave New World*, a dystopian novel set in a futuristic World State. The title comes from a quote: "How beauteous mankind is! O brave new world, that has such people in 't." Which playwright wrote these lines?



Irish playwright George Bernard Shaw became the first person to win which two awards? (GETTY IMAGES)

4 Born on July 26, 1919, James Lovelock was a British scientist who formulated the Gaia hypothesis. It proposes that all living organisms interact to form a self-regulating complex to sustain life on Earth. In which iconic 90s TV show was Gaia transformed into the spirit of the Earth inspiring youngsters to save the planet?

5 Born on this date in 1943, Mick Jagger is an English musician who founded one of the longest-running rock & roll bands of all time, The Rolling Stones. The iconic

logo of a tongue sticking out from the mouth was a recreation suggested by Jagger. It's derived from which Hindu Goddess of Time, Death and Destruction?

6 Born on July 26, 1945, Helen Mirren is an award-winning English actress who was part of the Royal Shakespeare Company. In 2003, she was made Dame Commander of the Order of the British Empire. This brought her in front of someone whom she had played onscreen to win an Oscar. Who was this person?

7 Born on July 26, 1964, Sandra Bullock is an award-winning actress known for her comedy and drama filmography. Surprisingly, her breakout role that brought her global fame was an action thriller where she drives a bus. Which 1994 movie was this that was a run-away hit?

8 Born on this date in 1967, Jason Statham is an English actor known for his tough guy persona onscreen. Before his stardom, he represented England in the 1990 Commonwealth Games. His athleticism helped him

do stunts in his action films, especially jumping off heights. What sport did he take part in?

9 Born on July 26, 1975, Mary Elizabeth Truss is a former prime minister of the United Kingdom who served just 49 days before resigning. *The Daily Star* compared her rocky tenure to a vegetable and even live-streamed one. Eventually, she left before it wilted. What vegetable now features on her Wikipedia profile?

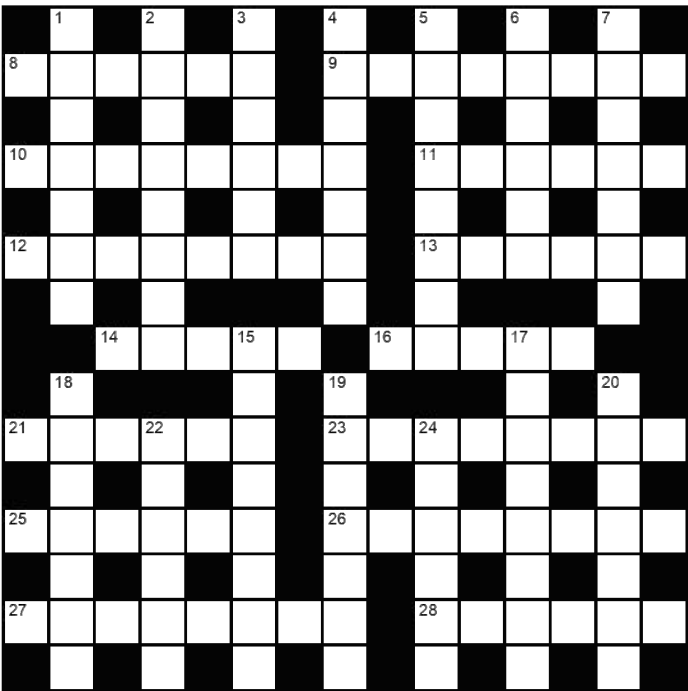
10 Born on this date in 1980, Jacinda Ardern went on to become the youngest female head of government in the world at the age of 37. In June 2018, she became only the second elected world leader to do something while in office. What did she do that only Benazir Bhutto had done in 1990?

A molecular biologist from Madurai, our quizmaster enjoys trivia and music, and is working on a rock ballad called 'Coffee is a Drink, Kaapi is an Emotion'. @bertyashley

- 1. Nobel Prize and Oscar Award
- 2. BTS
- 3. William Shakespeare
- 4. Captain Planet and the Planeteers
- 5. Kali
- 6. Queen Elizabeth II
- 7. Speed
- 8. Diving
- 9. Cabbage
- 10. Gave birth to her child

Answers

THE HINDU SUNDAY CROSSWORD NO. 66 (Set by Vidwan)



Across

8 Reveal it, without small act (6)

9 Help! Miss! Help! (8)

10 Fudge made with rare sugar from the Caribbean (8)

11 Dissidence as a result of this small British trading (6)

12 One who teaches baroque art deco outside university? (8)

13 Country crossing line for Spain and Portugal (6)

14 Hardback? (5)

16 Most sensible thing about a barbarian (5)

21 Criticises and pans! Could be snappiness! (6)

23 Just an international body located outside India (8)

25 Revolutionary shine and spirit (6)

26 Victory for Norway! Five Star perhaps for creative discipline! (4,4)

27 Victory to India's ruling coalition! Alcohol regularly relished in Goa! (8)

28 Millions wanting rock singer with high pitch (6)

5 Preserve energy, note and run into light (8)

6 Issue schemer generally covers (6)

7 Ties of blood and skin, first to finish in style! (7)

15 US Midwest bluster withered over time (4,4)

17 Audience notice better looking sailor (8)

18 In essence, lunch ain't free! (7)

19 Discharge pimp wasting time on backsliding womaniser (7)

20 Drunk pal kept giving motivational address (3,4)

22 Standard publicity over electronic display (6)

24 Bad smell surrounding old lousy egg fish (6)

SOLUTION NO. 65



Written and visual essays in this experimental publication encourage readers to explore everything from music and food to literature and fashion

TASTE, WHAT AI CAN'T FAKE

Smitha Menon

It's been almost six months since my daughter was born. We're past the baby blob stage and she finally seems to be taking an interest in the books I'm reading to her: crushing the crinkly pages of a fabric book, giggling when I lift a flap to reveal a hiding monkey. Sure, she is as fascinated by her toes as she is by books, but it's a start, right?

This daily exercise reminded me of the thrill of tactile books and has left me longing to sink back into the sensorial luxury that is reading. As a new mum, I do my fair share of doomscrolling, but in an age of AI-outsourced everything, reading a real book – not for self-help or upskilling, but for the sheer pleasure of it – seems almost illicit. Perhaps that's why I've been craving something that engages the senses rather than just the algorithm.

To me, *Taste*, an experimental, limited-edition publication by Juggernaut Books, feels both personal and political. Edited by journalist Lakshmi Chaudhry and designed by graphic designer Kriti Monga, this "part art object, part literary magazine" explores the idea of taste through written and visual essays that span music, food, travel, literature, culture, spaces, history, fashion and identity.

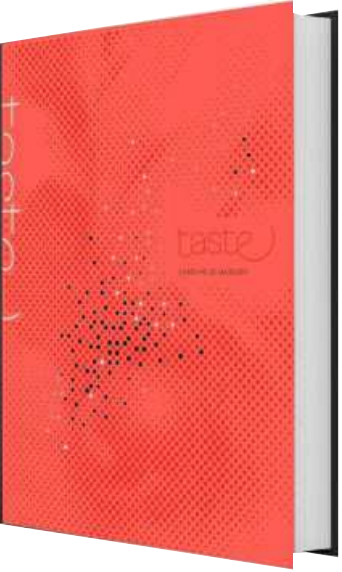
To call *Taste* a coffee-table book would be doing it a disservice, because it is as much a collection of literary writing as it is a work of delightful design that invites a reader to slow down and be enchanted – by an anaglyph on the story of Madras Checks; to ponder the journey of the pineapple, from fruit to luxury

statement; to examine the unlikely popularity of the music of Boney M in India. Published in a finite edition of 500 copies, *Taste* is the first of an annual imprint that costs ₹15,000.

Appealing to the mind and the senses

"Taste isn't just personal. It's not as simple as, 'Oh, I like this better than that'," says Chaudhry to me, over the phone. "If you start asking why people like certain things, you quickly realise it's a rabbit hole. It's a deceptively simple question with incredibly complex answers." Having worked in journalism for two decades covering war, genocide and terrorism, Chaudhry, per her introduction in the book, "ached to create something of beauty and meaning in a world greatly short on both". And what a beauty *Taste* is.

The book appeals to both the cerebral – with writing by the likes of author Aatish Taseer, journalist and



translator Srinath Perur and Nobel Prize laureate Abhijit Banerjee – and the sensory, with its use of creative art and varied printing innovations. A product that doesn't soothe, but challenges, the brain. Take for instance, a conversation between critic and writer Parul Sehgal with Kannada writer Vivek Shanbag on how language shapes our worldview, rearranging things that feel worthy and beautiful per the context of words. Says Shanbag, "For me, taste must have two things: surprise and tolerance. Both are essential, and both shape how one writes."

Over the course of the conversation, Sehgal says to Shanbag, "You're helping me see that taste isn't just a matter of aesthetics or style or personality but an orientation. It can be the ability to arrange oneself to be present for an encounter. To grapple with the unknown."

It's this grappling with the

unknown that author Meenakshi Reddy Madhavan explores when she embarks on a *Dilhale Dulhania Le Jayenge*-themed bus tour of Switzerland, with a gang of tentative countrymen who view the Swiss countryside through the comforting lens of filmmaker Aditya Chopra. These layered ideas of identity and migration are carried forward in visual essays that trace the journeys of the *kamarband*, from temple *yakshi* goddesses to James Bond; and *bandhani*, from Sindh to gang-coded bandanas in Los Angeles.

The book comes at an opportune time. The discourse around taste, the lack of it, its importance has never been louder. Do we actually like things because we genuinely do or because everyone – and hence, the algorithm – does?

Meant to be dipped into

Designed as an artistic endeavour, *Taste* doesn't spoon feed opinions.



(Clockwise from left) Lakshmi Chaudhry; Kriti Monga; and pages and illustrations from the book *Taste*. (COURTESY JUGGERNAUT BOOKS)



across the pages, and comes with an enclosed hand painted travel guide. The essay on India's elite living rooms resembling a generic hotel style, follows a design that's almost architectural in its scope, with block-like chunks of text that resemble skyscrapers.

As enjoyable as the reading experience is, I do wish some essays explored their subject areas with more depth. For instance, while the conversation between Abhijit Banerjee and some of India's top chefs on the changing idea of Indian cuisine is interesting, it sadly does not add anything new to the conversations already out there. The Bhadrakolk essay too, left me wanting for more.

Still, the book endures. To me, its greatest triumph is that it is an invitation. To critique, to read, to think and discuss. To delight in postcard prints, trace the journey of the pineapple across a map with your finger and lose an afternoon exploring new ideas and contexts.

As I type this, I catch my daughter gnawing on the edge of the book. I scramble to save it from her saliva, but what can I say? She clearly has great taste.

The writer is a food and travel journalist, and the host of the Big Food Energy podcast.

On a crisp spring afternoon, Phuphee and I were sitting on the verandah chatting after our lunch. She had rustled up a simple dish of *pootche gande ti thool* (spring onions and eggs) and served it with hot rice and *roahane koadur aanchaar* (a pickle made from the tender green stems of young garlic).

She was telling me the recipe for *pootche gande* when the gate opened and a large party of people walked in. Before they reached the verandah, she called for Aisha, the household help, to bring the samovar, *chinippyale* (small cups without handles) and some *kulchas*.

The party was headed by an elderly gentleman who looked annoyed and angry. Before he even sat down and caught his breath, he started narrating his tale of woe. 'Kyhaz dapai hamsheera, maehaz chu sitam. Yemyis nechtvyis karyov khaandar badyeav armaanoav magar nazar laeji kamiystaansinz.' (What can I tell you, my sister. I am facing such hardship. We got this son of ours married with so many hopes and dreams, but I don't know who has given us the evil eye.)

He sat before Phuphee beating his chest with his hands. It startled me a little, but Phuphee didn't so much as flinch. She watched him calmly and, after he had tired a little, he sat back and pretended to cry.



A LITTLE LIFE

The jinn that wasn't

A tale of superstition, family politics and a formidable Phuphee who refuses to let injustice pass

Phuphee asked him to speak plainly about why he had come. He stopped his non-crying and wiped his non-existent tears with the sleeve of his *pheran*. He proceeded to tell her about the young woman who was standing at the back. She was his daughter-in-law and he was sure that either someone had given the entire family the evil eye or she had been possessed by a *jinn*, for she behaved most abominably towards him.

'How so?' Phuphee asked. 'Yihaz chenna myesyith kathai karaan. Amyis chu shayad praah gomut (She isn't speaking to me at all. I think she has been possessed)', he replied, looking at the young woman crossly. Phuphee sat watching them for a few moments and then asked the daughter-in-law and her husband to come forward. 'Is this true?' she asked them. They nodded silently. Phuphee looked at the young woman and told her to speak openly.

'He speaks to me unkindly, often treating me as an outsider. He hurls abuses at my parents and other family members. If anything goes wrong in our home, he puts the blame at my feet. He seems to feel that it is acceptable for him to treat me this way because I am his daughter-in-law. There was nothing else I could do to hold him accountable, so I simply stopped speaking to him,' the young woman explained calmly.

'See! See, my sister, how she speaks. No respect for her elders, no respect for you,' he said, his voice now shrill and his manner aggressive. Phuphee took a deep breath and asked them all to sit for a while and have some *kehwe*. She instructed the father-in-law to follow her inside and asked Aisha to bring his *kehwe ti kulche*. Twenty minutes later, they returned to the verandah where everyone was waiting. She walked towards the

daughter-in-law and whispered something in her ear. Once everyone had finished their drinks, she bid them all goodbye.

Once we were alone, I asked Phuphee what she had whispered in the young woman's ear.

'I told her to come back in a week's time and tell me how everything is at home,' she replied.

'That's it?' I asked, a little surprised. 'But what about the exorcism?'

'I think you have had too much *aanchaar* today, *myoan jaan* [my life]. Go walk it off,' she replied, amused by my question. She got up and disappeared into the house.

I saw Aisha sweeping the garden with a *kaend doaph* (broom). She watched me as I walked towards her and smiled. I asked her to tell me what had happened inside.

Aisha explained that Phuphee had told the father-in-law that it was true, his daughter-in-law had indeed been possessed. But it was not just her, his son was in trouble, too. Sometimes *jinn*s came in pairs, she had told the gentleman. The pair of *jinn*s were too powerful for spells. If she attempted an exorcism and failed, they would both perish. Upon hearing that he could lose his only son, the gentleman had fallen quiet and asked if there was another way. Phuphee had told him the only options he had

were to either keep them both at home and treat them with the respect that *jinn*s of this calibre commanded or he expel them both from the family home. The gentleman decided he wanted to keep his son at home.

I looked at Aisha, puzzled. 'I have already said too much. I really couldn't stand life as a goat,' Aisha laughed, and before she disappeared into the house, she turned around and said, 'Sometimes entitlement runs so deep, it feels demonic when you finally have to face it. I guess everything changes when you have skin in the game, right?'

I picked up the broom and started sweeping the garden clean of the leaves and twigs that a mild wind had blown in yesterday. As I swept, I wondered when Phuphee would do some real magic, the kind that included incantations and bubbling cauldrons.

But one day down the years, I would realise that I had been too young and too naïve to understand that real magic was rarely visible to the naked eye. Instead, it moved around like a zephyr, unseen and invisible, but with the gentle power to move destinies.

Saba Mahjoor, a Kashmiri living in England, spends her scant free time contemplating life's vagaries.



ZAINAB TAMBIAWALLA